Avasthy was to have taken over 2 Rajput, but since Rikh was continuing as its CO, Avasthy had been given command of 4 Rajput, a battalion he was not at all familiar with. The new commanding officer brought with him a solid reputation as being one of the best mid-ranking officers in the Indian Army at the time.

The primary task of 4 Rajput was to protect Bridge 1 on the Dirang–Se-la-Jang road, so the battalion shifted its HQ to the vicinity of Sappers Camp. With Kukrety's company watching over the footpaths that skirted Se-la from the west, it was decided that Alpha Company, under Major K. P. P. Nair, would move along the Nyukmadong track to the east to watch over tracks emanating down from Tangyap-la, Kye-la and Se-la.

Once again, GOC 4 Division, Anant Pathania, briefed the company commander, Nair, personally in the presence of both Avasthy and the new brigade commander, Brigadier A. S. Cheema. An officer from 2 Grenadiers who served under him confirmed to me that Cheema, who had commanded 2 Grenadiers in Ambala previously, was considered tactically useless, with a penchant for keeping his immediate superiors happy. The task for Nair's men would be to keep an eye on Chinese troop movement in and around Dzalung-la and deny them the use of the tracks which led down to the Dirang–Se-la road. Taking Nair aside, the brigade commander told the Alpha Company Commander to make sure he had the GOC's orders 'in writing in his own interest'.

On 10 November, Alpha company set off in bitterly cold conditions, with thick fog restricting visibility to around five metres. Nair was to describe the conditions: 'The terrain along the route is mountainous heights varying from 10,000 to 14,000 feet above sea level and covered with dense forest. The area is interspersed with finger-like ridges separated by valleys through which flow streams. The tracks are actually footpaths not more than 3 feet in width. In this sort of terrain it is not possible to maintain a steady marching speed along tracks which in addition to being narrow are tortuous. There are steep ascends and sharp descends. The distances between places are expressed in terms of the time taken to traverse them. In areas where enemy presence is suspected, the ground in front has to be searched while moving forward. Half a kilometre an hour would be a reasonable call of speed of movement.'

On 11 November, the company halted at Dher Gompa where they had to await the arrival of the porters who arrived by midday. The porters refused